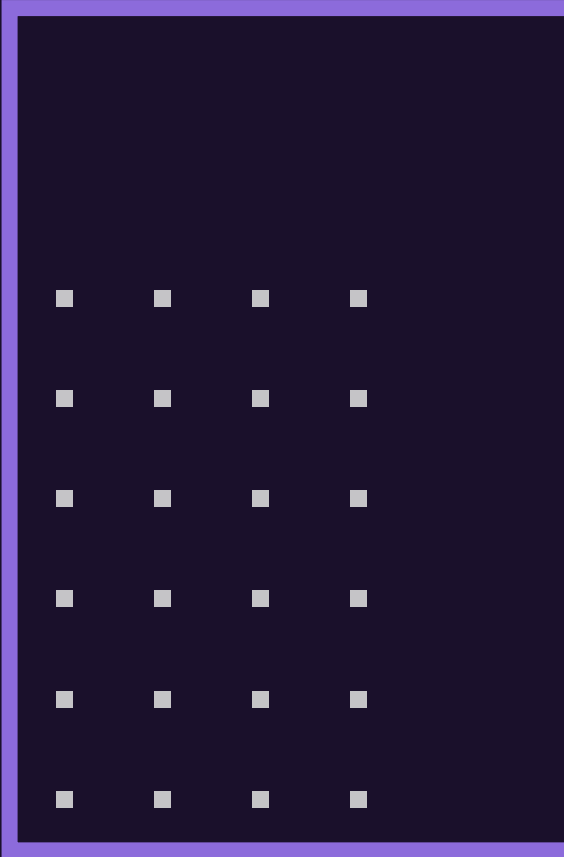
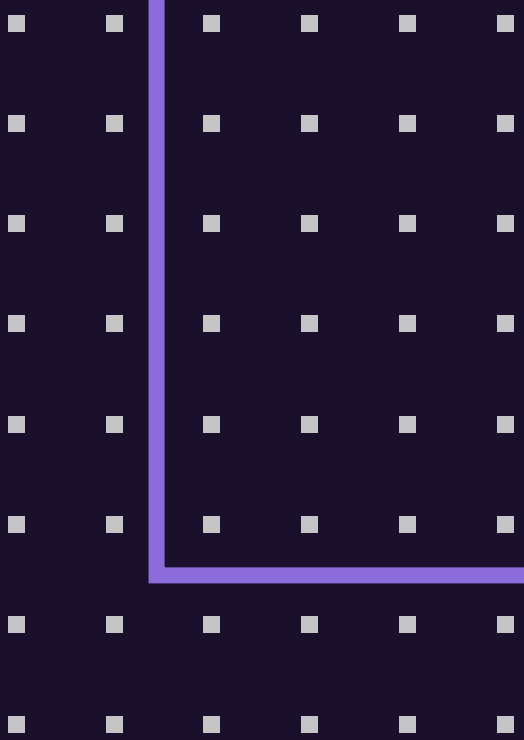
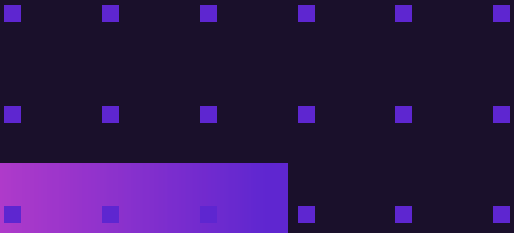




hiya

STATE OF THE CALL 2026

Based on a survey of more than
12,000 consumers in the US, Canada,
UK, Spain, France and Germany

hiya.com/state-of-the-call

INTRODUCTION

Consumers' trust in phone calls is eroding, but opportunities abound for mobile network operators who offer strong spam protection

In the past, a ringing phone might bring excitement and anticipation of talking to a friend or loved one. Today, it's more likely to elicit concern and anxiety.

Much of that is driven by the proliferation of scam calls, spam calls, and unidentified phone numbers. Consumers' trust in phone calls is eroding, and they want mobile network operators to be the primary line of defense.

Those are just some of the findings from Hiya's annual State of the Call report, which is based on

survey data from more than 12,000 consumers in six key countries: the United States, Canada, the UK, France, Germany, and Spain.

Of particular interest to mobile network operators, this report gauges consumer sentiment regarding their mobile phone use, exposure to unwanted calls, and overall trust in the voice channel.

As we've seen in previous years, consumers continue to value the intimacy and immediacy of a phone call and prefer it for their most important communications.

39%

say spam is increasing

38%

say they'd switch from a network that doesn't protect them

But threats exist. Consumers admit that their trust in phone calls is eroding. Much of that is driven by the proliferation of scam calls, increasingly fueled by AI agents that allow scammers to scale their operations and target victims with precision. Consumers say they receive an average of 7 unwanted calls every week, and phone scams are escalating faster than traditional defenses can keep up with.

Globally, 15% of respondents said they lost money to a phone scam in the past year, resulting in billions lost worldwide. Even more frightening

to consumers are new, AI-assisted deepfake scams that are even harder to detect.

Survey respondents rate protection from unwanted calls as one of their top reasons for choosing a network

— or switching to a competitor. The good news is that solutions exist for protecting against scam and spam calls, and even for detecting AI-generated voices. Mobile network operators who adopt these technologies will gain a competitive advantage.

"I felt threatened and upset [after receiving a fake call]. It taught me not to trust calls anymore."

— Survey respondent

Our survey shows that voice security can no longer be an afterthought. It's a business imperative for protecting revenue, reducing churn, heading off costly regulations, and building brand reputation.

Read on to see the five major trends that surfaced in this year's State of the Call survey, as well as Hiya's recommendations for both mobile network operators and businesses that depend on phone conversations to grow their companies.

Methodology

Censuswide conducted market research on behalf of Hiya between December 17, 2025 and January 2, 2026. The survey included responses from more than 12,000 consumers based in the US, Canada, UK, France, Germany, and Spain. There were approximately 2,000 respondents from each country. Censuswide is a member of the Market Research Society and adheres to its code of conduct, which is based on ESOMAR principles.

Top voice call trends for 2026

Based on this year's State of the Call survey, the data highlights five key trends. Each is introduced here and explored in greater detail in the sections that follow.

- 1 Consumer frustration with unwanted calls continues to increase year over year.** Consumers say they receive an average of 7 unwanted calls per week, and 15% have lost money to phone scams in the past year.
- 2 AI is making voice fraud worse, both in volume and in targeting.** 31% of consumers say they've received a deepfake voice call, and they believe scammers, not mobile network operators, are winning.
- 3 Subscribers believe their mobile network operator should be responsible for protecting them against voice fraud.** 31% of consumers say network operators should take the lead role in stopping phone scams — and should help cover the cost of losses.
- 4 Eroding trust is crippling the voice channel.** 86% of consumers don't answer unknown phone numbers, and they want businesses to identify themselves on caller ID when they call.
- 5 Mobile network operators with strong spam protection have a huge competitive advantage.** 35% of consumers say protection from spam calls is one of the top factors they consider when choosing a network.

TREND 1

Consumer frustration with unwanted calls is increasing

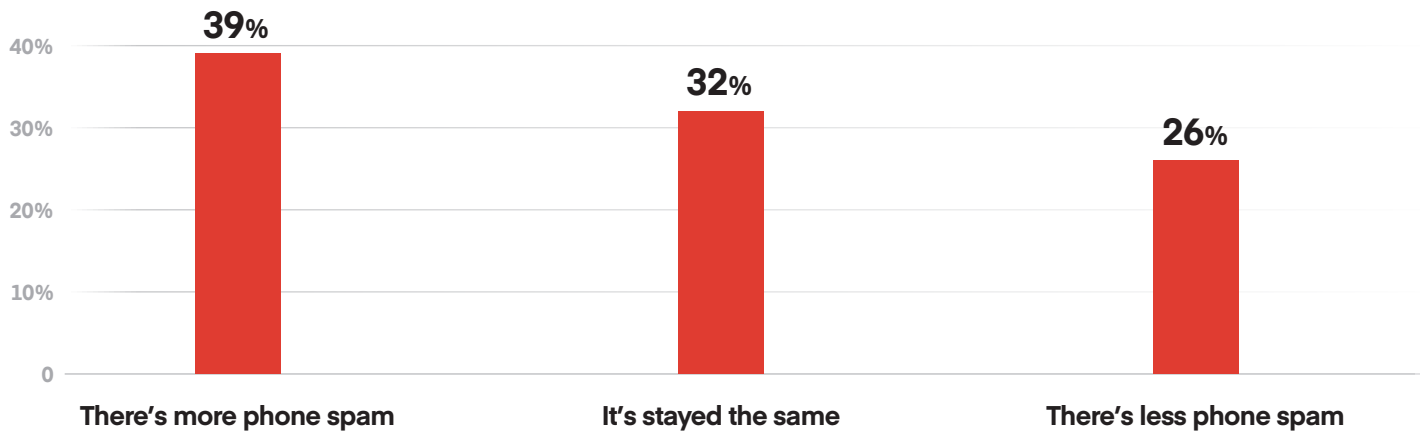
One of the main frustrations consumers have with their mobile phones is the proliferation of unwanted calls. These range from nuisance telemarketing calls to phone scams intent on stealing money or personal information.

The prevalence of both fraud and nuisance calls has led to a lack of trust in phone calls in general. In fact, more than a third of respondents (34%) say their overall trust in phone calls has decreased, while only 16% say it has increased.

Furthermore, consumers believe that the amount of phone spam they receive is increasing. 39% of respondents said there has been more phone spam in the past year, while only 26% said there is less.

34%
of respondents say their overall trust in phone calls has decreased in the past 12 months

How, if at all, has phone spam changed for you in the last 12 months, versus the prior 12 months?



“A scam call affected my elderly relative. They lost over \$900 from their pension. It was very violating and completely wrong for someone to take advantage of someone who is so vulnerable.”

– Survey respondent

Consumers are losing significant amounts of money to phone scams

Consumers are frustrated. They say they receive an average of 7 unwanted calls per week. Of course, the number of unwanted calls varies significantly by country, ranging from 4 calls per week in the UK to 12 calls per week in France.

There's one statistic that hasn't changed. This year, 15% of respondents said they lost money to a phone scam. That figure has remained constant the past 3 years, despite ongoing investments in voice security by mobile network operators and device manufacturers.

The amount of money lost to phone scams also varies by country. For respondents who said they lost money to a phone scam in the last year, shown here is the average amount lost.



United Kingdom

Amount lost to phone scams
(past 12 months)

£784



Canada

Amount lost to phone scams
(past 12 months)

CA\$1,208



Germany

Amount lost to phone scams
(past 12 months)

€749



Spain

Amount lost to phone scams
(past 12 months)

€515



United States

Amount lost to phone scams
(past 12 months)

\$682



France

Amount lost to phone scams
(past 12 months)

€628

AI is making voice fraud worse, and consumers are increasingly experiencing deepfake calls

AI is weaponizing the voice channel, with automated AI agents increasing the volume of attacks and deepfake technology making targeting more effective.

In this year’s poll, nearly one in three respondents (31%)

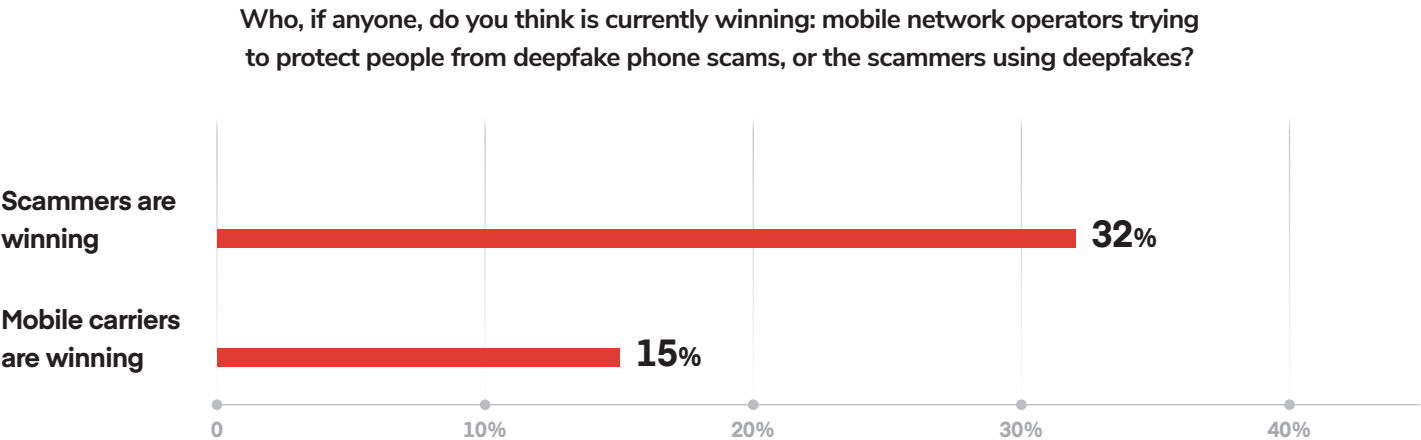
said they had received a deepfake voice call in the past 12 months. That’s where scammers use artificial intelligence to clone the voice of someone the victim recognizes. Another 15% say they don’t know if they’ve experienced a deepfake — underscoring how realistic these calls can be.

“My 90-year-old mother received a scam call with a deepfake voice of her grandson asking for money, claiming he was in jail. My sister was there, and they didn’t fall for it. However, my Mom was so shaken up by the call that she refused to answer the phone unless someone was there with her for many months.”

– Survey respondent

Our survey also asked consumers who they thought is most susceptible to deepfakes. Respondents believe that it’s our most vulnerable populations: those 75 years and older and children under the age of 18.

Perhaps most concerning of all is that consumers believe it’s the scammers — not mobile network operators — who are winning the deepfake battle. 32% say scammers are winning, while only 15% say MNOs are winning. The rest believe it’s about even or don’t know.



Subscribers believe mobile network operators should be responsible for protecting them against voice fraud

The reality is that the battle against fraud calls is fought on many fronts. It's a combined effort that includes law enforcement, governmental regulators, technology companies, and mobile network operators. But when you ask consumers which entity is primarily responsible for stopping voice fraud, the answer is clear. Of the six countries surveyed, all but one said mobile network operators have the primary responsibility.

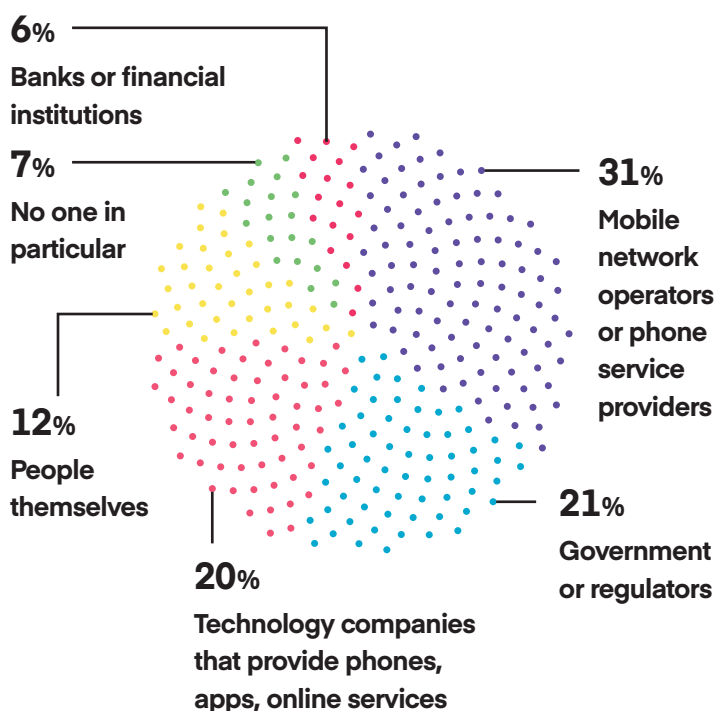
31% said MNOs should have the primary role, while only 21% said it should be the government's role.

Assigning primary responsibility to mobile network operators, it's not surprising that the majority of consumers (65%) felt that MNOs should be subject to stronger regulations.

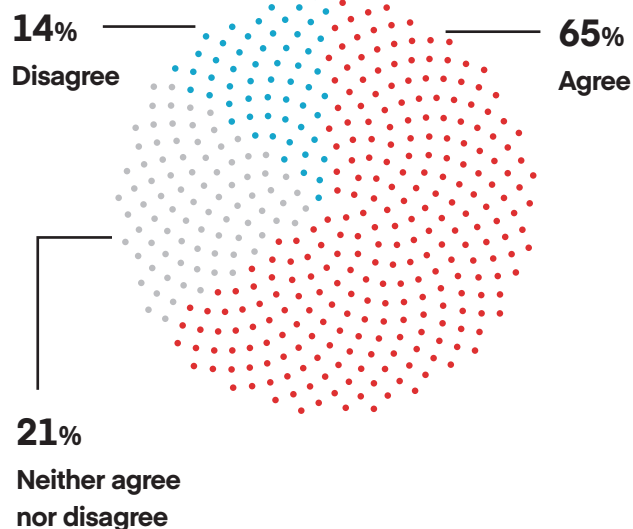
"It made me feel sad that the phone company I'm with isn't doing more to prevent these calls."

– Survey respondent

Who should be most responsible for stopping phone scams and deepfake phone scams before they reach people like you?



To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statement: "Mobile network operators should be subject to stronger regulations to protect customers from phone scams."



Who should pay for financial losses?

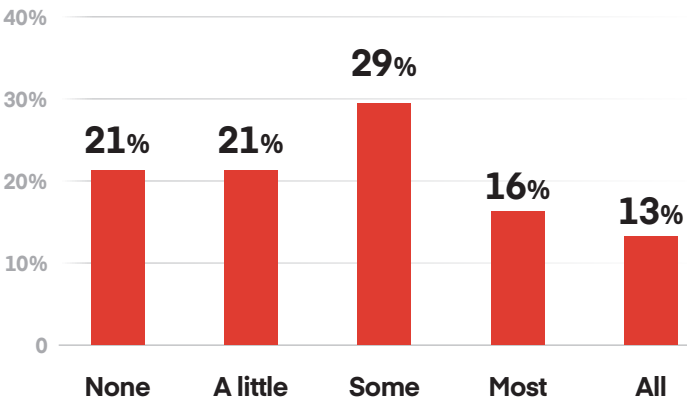
Not only do consumers believe that mobile network operators should be the ones leading the fight against fraud calls, but they also feel that MNOs should have some financial responsibility when their subscribers

lose money as a result of a phone scam. More than half of respondents (53%) said they think MNOs should cover at least some of the loss, and 13% believe MNOs should bear the full cost.

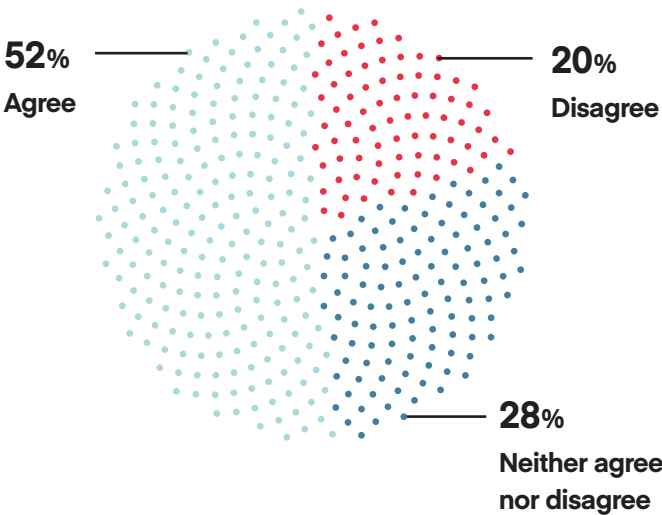
Other consumers take a harder line. More than half (52%) say that MNOs

should offer zero-liability fraud protection like credit cards do, so if subscribers lose money to a phone scam that reaches them through a certain network, that same network would reimburse them.

If you lost money to a phone scam that started with a call or text to your mobile phone, how much responsibility, if any, should your mobile network operator have for covering your loss?



To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statement: “Mobile network operators should offer zero-liability fraud protection like credit cards do, so that if you lose money to a phone scam that reached you through their network, the network reimburses you.”



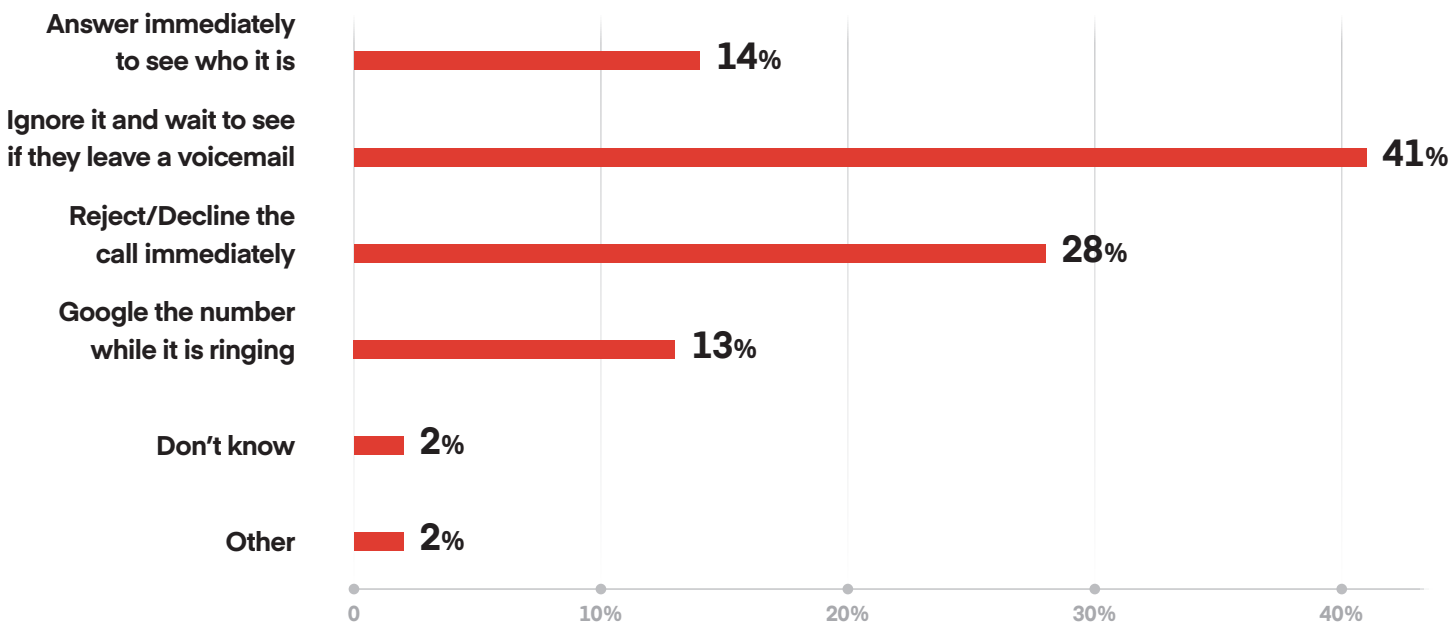
Eroding trust is crippling the voice channel

Trust in voice calls is declining. In fact, our survey found that the vast majority of unidentified calls go unanswered. Unidentified calls come from phone numbers that are not in an individual's personal contact list. They may simply display a phone number, a location, or "unknown caller."

When consumers receive calls from numbers they don't recognize, only 14% immediately answer — meaning 86% do not answer unknown calls. They're more likely to either reject the call immediately (28%) or ignore it and see if the caller leaves a voicemail (41%).

86%
of consumers don't answer unidentified calls

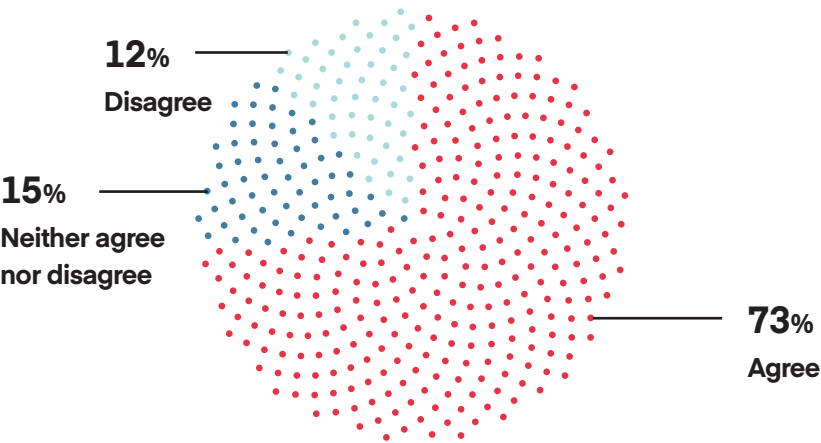
When you receive a call from a number you don't recognize, what is your default action?



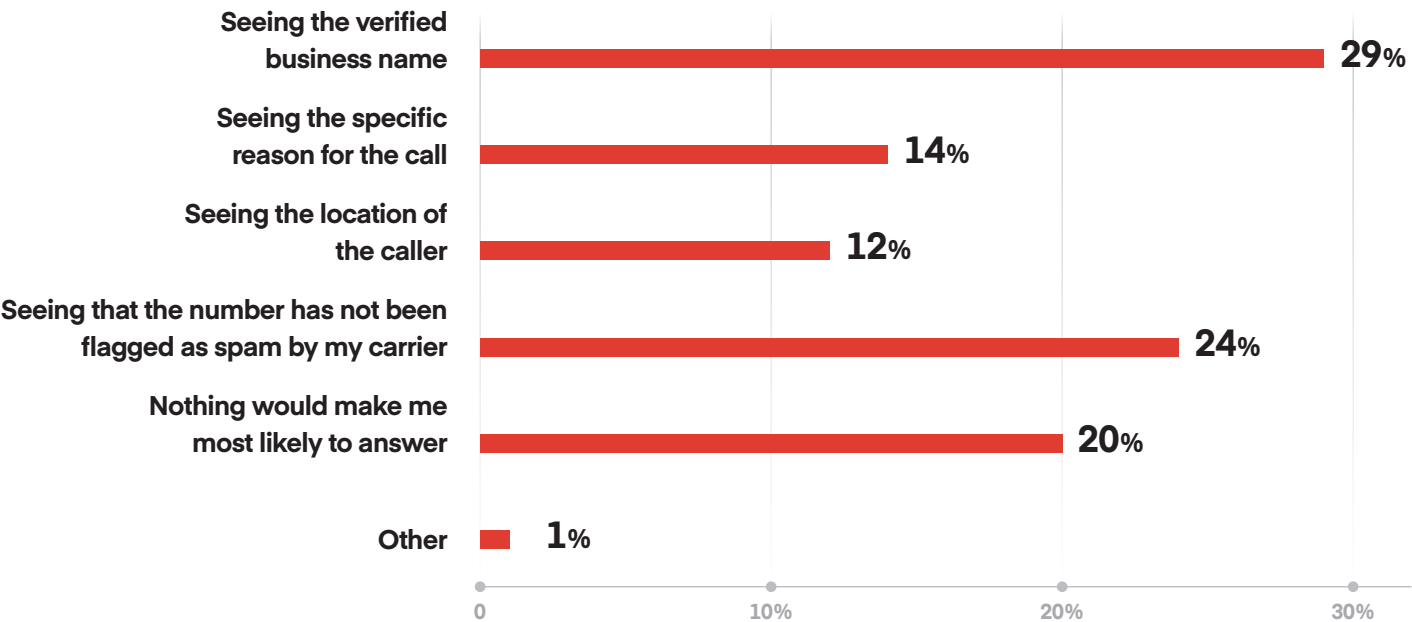
Consumers want businesses to identify themselves

How can companies get through to customers and prospects when most people won't even answer their phone? The answer: consumers say they want businesses to identify themselves on caller ID. And the one piece of information that would make them more likely to answer is the business's name.

To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statement: "Businesses should identify themselves in caller ID when they call me."



If a business is calling you, what, if any, single piece of information would make you most likely to answer?



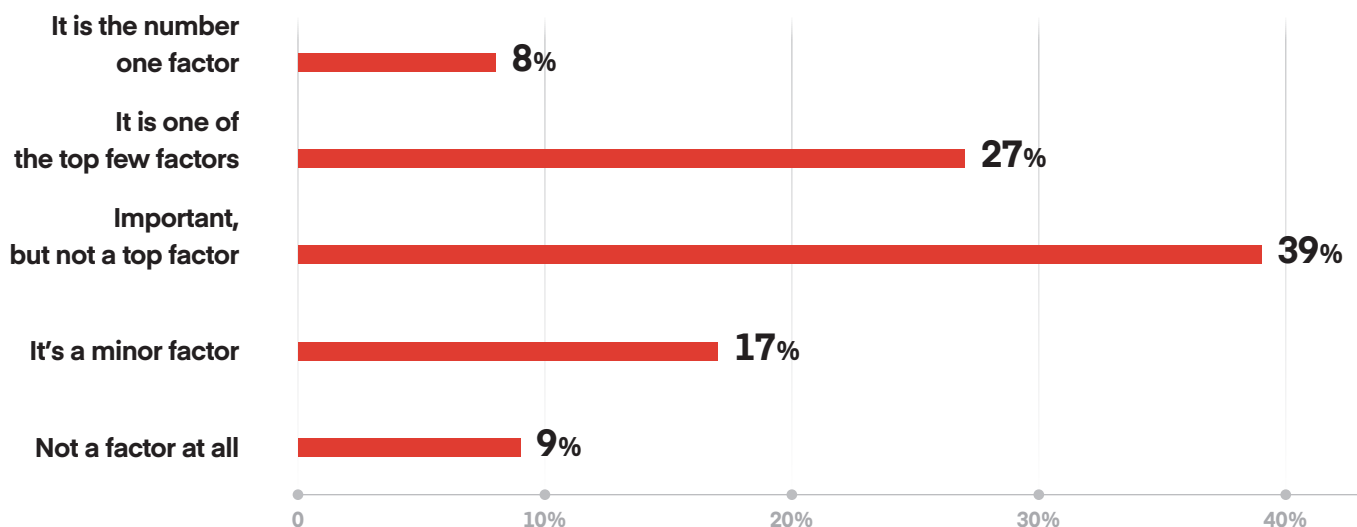
Mobile network operators with strong spam protection have a huge competitive advantage

Our survey tells us that protection from spam calls is a meaningful consideration for consumers when choosing a mobile network operator — or deciding to switch networks.

Many factors go into consumers' selection of a mobile network operator, including the price and network coverage area. High on that list is the network's ability

to protect consumers from unwanted calls. More than a third of respondents (35%) rank spam protection among their top reasons for selecting an MNO, with 8% of those respondents saying it is the number one factor. That's a huge growth opportunity for MNOs. That means the network with the best spam protection should be able to lure 8% of subscribers from each competitor.

When you think about staying with or switching your mobile network operator, how big a factor, if at all, is protection from spam calls and deepfake scam calls compared with things like price, coverage, and data speed?



Consumers with poor spam protection are more likely to switch networks

Not only do consumers consider spam protection when selecting a network, it's also one of the primary reasons for leaving their MNO and switching to a competitor.

Again, more than a third (38%) said they would be either likely or extremely likely to switch if their MNO was not doing enough to protect them.

"It's frustrating to know that vulnerable people are losing their life savings through a network they pay to keep them safe."

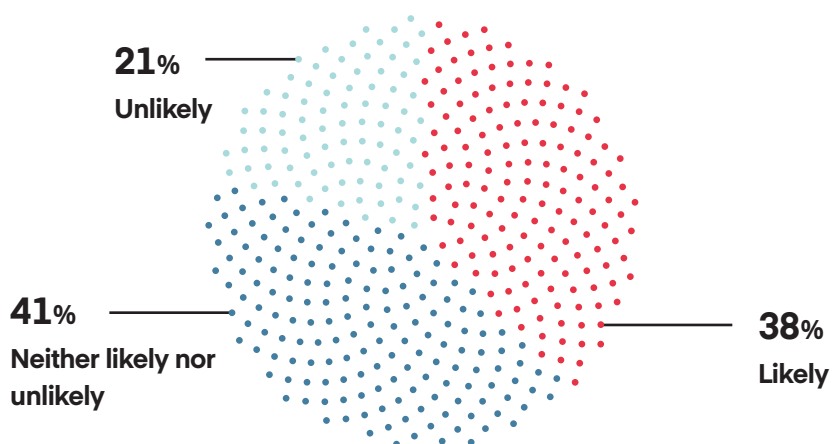
– Survey respondent

One-third of consumers don't use any call screening features

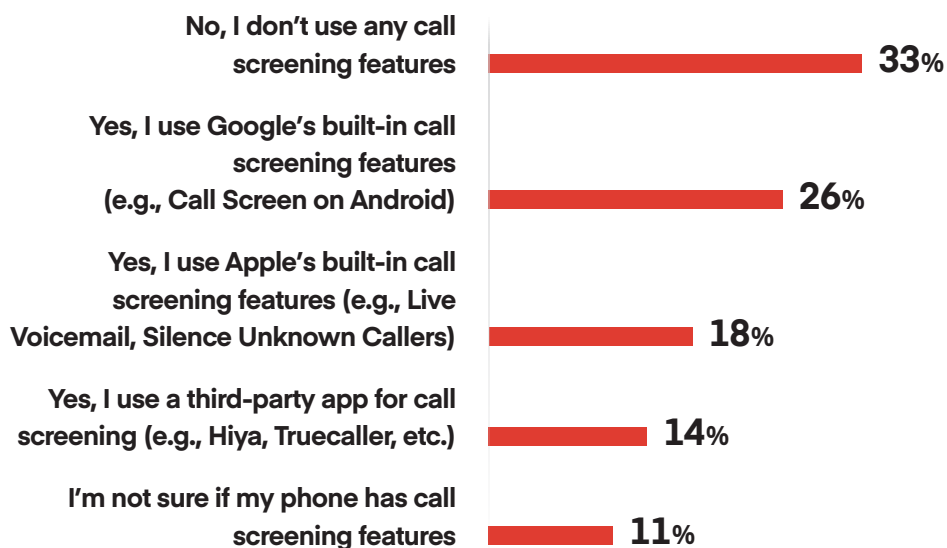
There is certainly a need for consumers to be better protected from spam and scam calls. However, a third of consumers (33%) don't use any call screening features. Those that do, most commonly use built-in services from their device manufacturer, which provide some protection, but can't stop fraud calls before they reach their device, like network-based spam protection can.

Also of note to MNOs is the fact that 11% of consumers don't even know if they have call screening features at all. Again, that's a big opportunity for MNOs that offer spam protection to promote it to their subscribers.

If you felt your mobile network operator was not doing enough to protect you from spam calls and deepfake phone scams, how likely or unlikely would you be to switch?



On your mobile phone, do you use any built-in or app-based call screening features that help filter or answer calls from unknown numbers on your behalf? (Select all that apply)



RECOMMENDATIONS

Given the critical role that voice calls play in both personal and business communication, what can mobile network operators and businesses do to help keep voice channels secure and reliable? Here are Hiya's recommendations.

Recommendations for mobile network operators

Add spam and fraud protection at the network level –

Consumers expect mobile network operators to protect them from fraud and nuisance calls. The best way to do that is by adding spam and fraud protection at the network level. Commonly, MNOs will block fraud calls and will label spam calls so subscribers can decide whether they want to answer.

Use AI-powered spam protection – Scammers are using AI to steal from subscribers, and mobile network operators must fight back with AI-powered solutions. AI scales fraud, so traditional defenses are no longer sufficient, making AI-powered spam protection a requirement rather than an option.

For example, [Hiya's spam protection service](#) uses AI to continuously adapt to new threats, combating fraud in real time. It uses a multi-layer approach that analyzes the incoming phone number, the call characteristics, the recipient of the call, and even the calling enterprise's history across all numbers used. Hiya also offers [AI voice detection](#), which can be integrated directly into the mobile network, protecting subscribers from this new and ever-evolving threat.

Promote your spam protection services — Our survey shows that many consumers don't even know if they have spam protection. That gives MNOs an opportunity to promote their services to customers, and to explain how network-based protection is superior to OEM hardware-based call screeners built into the device. Spam protection is a powerful differentiator, so MNOs will do well to promote their services to current subscribers and to win over new subscribers.

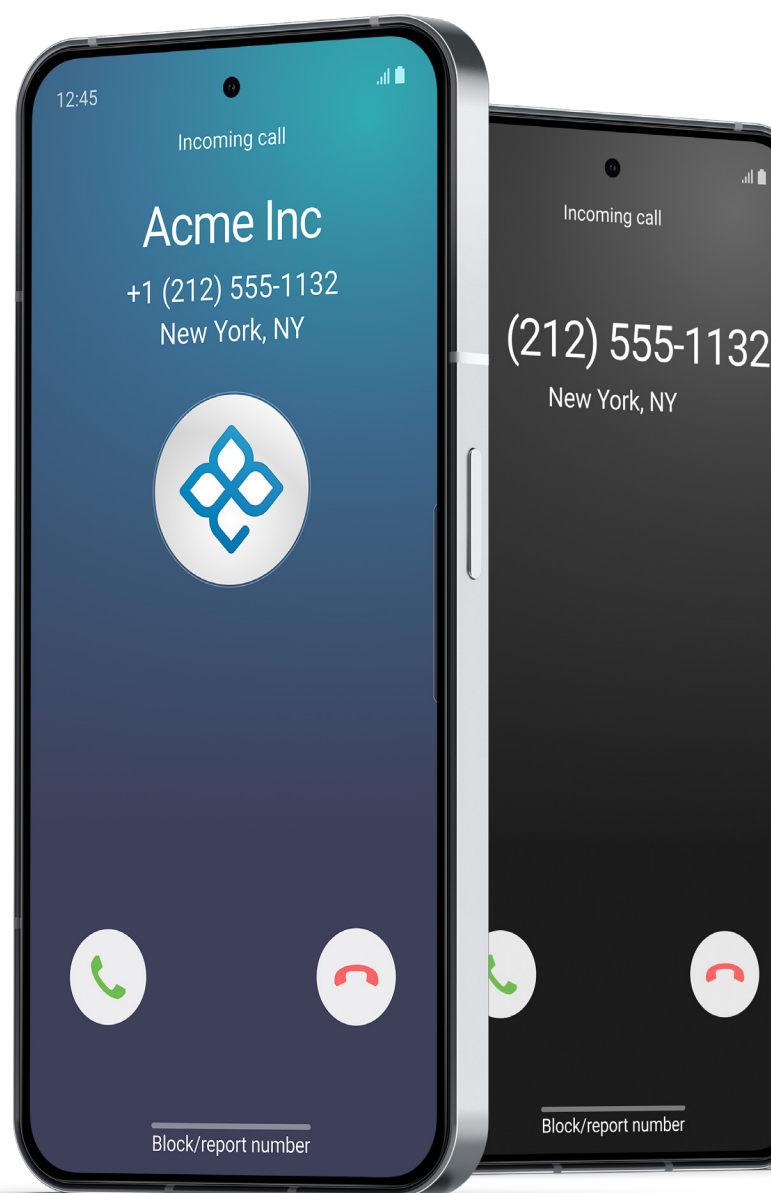


Recommendations for businesses

Add branded caller ID – The fact that **86%** of consumers don't answer unidentified calls is a clear message to businesses that calling customers or prospects from a random phone number is not going to be successful. People want to know exactly who is calling before they're willing to answer. Using **Hiya Branded Call** is a simple solution to that problem. It enables businesses to display their name, phone number, logo, and reason for the call on the recipient's mobile device. The best branded call providers also offer anti-spoofing technology to guard against fraudsters who use traditional caller ID to impersonate respected brands.

Register as a legitimate business – When spam analytic services encounter new phone numbers, they often treat them with caution. To counter this, businesses can **register their phone numbers**, which establishes them as a legitimate caller to MNOs that deliver their calls. It's an important — and free — step that every business making outbound calls should take.

Adopt inbound call protections – To reduce the risk of employees falling victim to fraud and deepfake calls, businesses can deploy inbound call protections. Look for solutions that offer **AI voice detection** that can identify deepfake calls and can warn employees in real time if fraud is suspected. These solutions operate at the mobile device and network level, automatically monitoring for incoming threats.



with
Branded Call

without
Branded Call

CONCLUSION

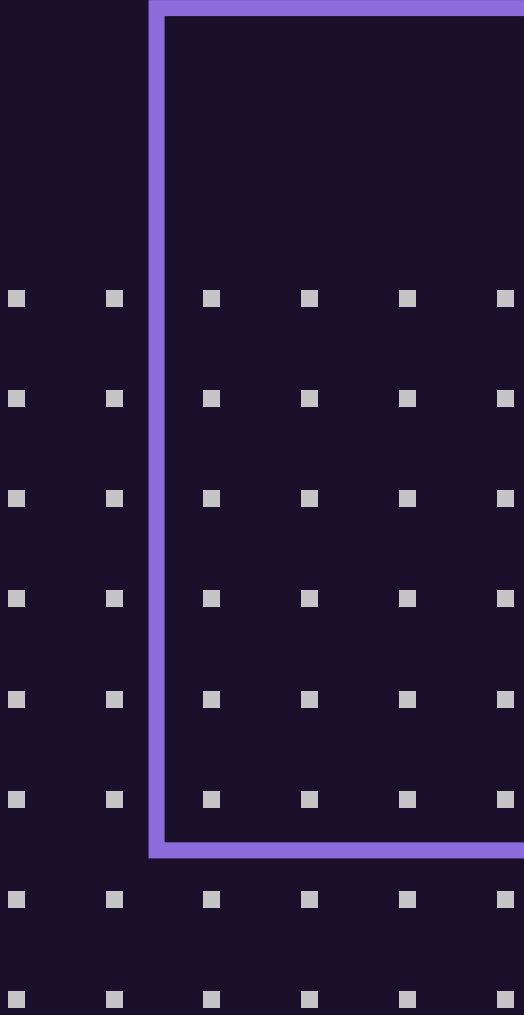
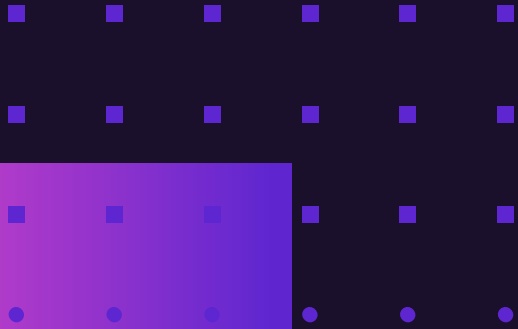
Safeguard the future of voice

The data is clear. Consumers prefer voice calls for their most important communications. Yet, too often, voice calls present challenges.

The proliferation of scam and spam calls has made consumers defensive whenever the phone rings. Unidentified phone numbers force subscribers to guess whether the caller is a scammer or a potential new client. And with the introduction of AI, voice cloning continues to become more and more accessible, which means deepfake scams will only continue to become more and more common.

The good news is that solutions to all of these challenges are readily available, and many mobile network operators are already taking advantage of them. However, others are missing out by not adopting the security protections available to them and their subscribers.

To safeguard the future of voice, now is the time to take action by deploying solutions that preserve voice as a safe, reliable, trustworthy means of communication.



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Learn more at hiya.com

Hiya is a global leader in trusted voice solutions, providing AI-powered caller identity, branded calling, and voice security at network scale. Trusted by Tier-1 mobile operators and leading enterprises worldwide, Hiya analyzes billions of calls annually to help make phone calls clear, safe, and worth answering again.